Fasting & Feasting

Rules — A Pattern-Building Card Game about the Coptic Calendar

Players	Ages	Time	Difficulty
2–5	**10+**	**20–30 min**	**Moderate**

> *"Moreover, when you fast, do not be like the hypocrites, with a sad countenance. But you, when you fast, anoint your head and wash your face." — Matthew 6:16–17*

About

The Coptic Orthodox Church fasts more than 200 days each year — more than any other Christian tradition. But fasting is never an end in itself. Every fast prepares the heart for a feast, and every feast gives meaning to the fast that preceded it. In this game, players learn the rhythm of the Coptic calendar by placing Season Cards onto the correct months of the Calendar Board, discovering how fasts, feasts, and saints' days weave together into a single pattern of worship.

Formation Goal

Players will learn the major fasts and feasts of the Coptic Church, understand how they connect to each other, and appreciate the rhythm of preparation and celebration that shapes the life of every Coptic Christian throughout the year.

Components

- **50 Season Cards** — 18 Fast Cards (stone background, red accent), 20 Feast Cards (white background, gold accent), and 12 Season/Saints Cards (purple background)
- **1 Calendar Board** — showing the 13 Coptic months arranged in a circle with card placement slots
- **1 Score Track** — printed along the bottom of the Calendar Board

Setup

1. Place the **Calendar Board** in the centre of the table.
2. Shuffle all 50 Season Cards face-down into a single draw pile.
3. Deal **5 cards** to each player (face-down; players may look at their own cards).
4. Place the remaining cards in a draw pile beside the board.
5. Each player starts at **0** on the score track.
6. The player whose birthday is nearest to Nayrouz (11 September) goes first.

How to Play

On your turn, follow these steps in order:

1. **Play a card.** Choose one Season Card from your hand and place it face-up on the Calendar Board in the Coptic month where you believe it belongs. Announce the name and type: "The Great Lent — a Fast, starting before Pascha."
2. **Explain the connection.** Read the linked fast or feast printed at the bottom of your card. If the linked card is already on the board, point to it and explain the connection in your own words (e.g., "The Advent Fast prepares us for the Nativity").
3. **Score points:**
   - **2 points** for placing a card in the correct month (or correct season for moveable feasts).
   - **1 bonus point** if the linked card is already on the board and you correctly explain the connection.
   - **0 points** if the placement is wrong. Another player may correct it and score 1 point.
4. **Draw a card** from the draw pile (if any remain) to refill your hand to 5.
5. Play passes **clockwise**.

Challenges

Any player may challenge a placement by saying "Challenge!" before the next player's turn begins.

- If the **challenge is correct** (the card was misplaced), the challenger moves the card to the right position and scores **1 point**. The original player scores **0**.
- If the **challenge is wrong** (the card was correctly placed), the original player scores an extra **1 bonus point** and the challenger loses **1 point**.
- Use the dates and descriptions on the card to resolve disputes.

Moveable Feasts

Some feasts (Pascha, Pentecost, Ascension, Palm Sunday, etc.) move each year because they depend on the date of Easter. For these cards, placement is correct if it falls within the range of months the event can occur in. The card text provides guidance.

End of Game

The game ends when all cards have been played or the draw pile is empty and no player has cards remaining. The player with the **most points** wins. In case of a tie, the player who made the most successful linking connections wins.

Scoring Summary

- **Correct placement:** 2 points
- **Linking bonus:** +1 point (linked card on board + explanation)
- **Successful challenge:** 1 point (to the challenger)
- **Defended challenge:** +1 point (to the original player)
- **Failed challenge:** −1 point (to the challenger)
- **Wrong placement:** 0 points

> **Tip for Servants:** Encourage players to explain connections in their own words rather than just reading the card. This builds deeper understanding. Ask follow-up questions: “Why do you think the Church fasts before this feast?”

Variants

Cooperative Mode (Ages 10+, any group size)

Play as a team. Take turns placing cards and discuss together where each card belongs. The goal is to place all 50 cards correctly. No individual scoring — count how many you got right as a group and try to beat your record next time.

Speed Round

Deal all cards evenly. No challenges — everyone places as quickly as possible. When all cards are placed, check together. Count correct placements as the group score.

Teaching Mode (for younger groups)

Play with cards face-up. The leader reads each card aloud and the group decides together where it goes. Use the Calendar Board as a visual aid to tell the story of the Coptic year from Nayrouz through to the Assumption.

Scripture Connections

> *“Is this not the fast that I have chosen: to loose the bonds of wickedness, to undo the heavy burdens, to let the oppressed go free?” — Isaiah 58:6*

> *“These things I have spoken to you, that My joy may remain in you, and that your joy may be full.” — John 15:11*

The Coptic calendar teaches us that fasting and feasting are not opposites — they are partners. The fast empties us so the feast can fill us. The feast gives us the strength and joy to fast again. Together, they form the heartbeat of the Church’s year.